[English text unavailable]

Contents

[English text unavailable] 2
[English text unavailable] 5
[English text unavailable] 8
[English text unavailable] 11
[English text unavailable] 13
[English text unavailable] 17
[English text unavailable] 19
[English text unavailable] 22

[English text unavailable]

COL-314601

The Young Traveler

Inn

Hotelier: A single room'll be four coins a night; breakfast delivered to your door'll be one coin extra.

Rhiannon: Alright, that makes five.

Rhiannon opens her coin purse and lets a few coins spill into her palm.

Adar Llwch Gwin Fledgling: Coo ...

The fledgling perched upside-down on her wand spots the glint of treasure and stretches out to snatch it.

Rhiannon: Stop it.

She flicks the bird's still-tender beak.

Adar Llwch Gwin Fledgling: Coo!

The fledgling gives an indignant little shake.

Hotelier: We don't turn away anyone here—witches, shamans, druids ... Why, even vampires'll get clean, cozy beds if they've the coin for it.

He glances at the two Adar Llwch Gwins.

Hotelier: Pets, though—those'll be two coins extra.

Rhiannon: T-Two?! No, that's too much! Oh, how about this! I'll clean the room before I go. You won't find so much as a single feather—promise!

A soft gray plume drifts onto the counter. Molting season strikes again.

Hotelier: ...

Rhiannon: ...

Hotelier: You know, we once had a guest who insisted on bringing his Ceffyl Dŵr inside. That water horse nearly flooded the whole room! Charged him for an entire new set of bedding, I did.

Hotelier: Be glad I'm only charging a coin per parrot.

Rhiannon: They're not parrots.

She mutters under her breath but relents, setting seven gleaming coins on the counter.

The lion cubs stamped on them roar silently at him.

Hotelier: And what would these be, miss?

Rhiannon: Sharpodonties, sir.

Hotelier: I know what they are, but we only take shillings, miss. Shillings!

Rhiannon: Shillings, um ...

This town may not bar its doors to arcanists, but it's far from being the witches' fair in Caernarfon.

Sharpodonties have never passed for legal tender in the mundane world. Folks around here are more familiar with the King's profile looking back at them as opposed to a snapping lion.

Rhiannon: R-Right.

She smiles sheepishly and begins digging through her bag.

Spare clothes, biscuits, a jar of chocolate spread ... So many items, yet not a trace of any human-accepted coins.

Hotelier: You DO have shillings, don't you, miss?

Rhiannon: O-Of course I do! It's just ...

She scratches her cheek, embarrassed.

Rhiannon: My mam threw me out, you see. It was all so sudden. I didn't really have the chance to pack proper money.

Hotelier: So, you haven't any then.

Rhiannon: I, erhm ...

He pushes the Sharpodonties back to her.

Hotelier: Best you go home and patch things up with your mam while there's still daylight? Better that than spending a night in the stable with your parrots.

Rhiannon: Oh, I know! How about I help you out around the hotel instead?

She's not ready to give up on a cozy bed just yet.

Rhiannon: I know plenty of handy arcane skills—boiling water without fire, prepping ingredients without a knife, and making a bed before you can even say "fluff the pillows."

Hotelier: With all due respect, miss, this isn't some pragmatist's office. I won't be responsible for putting my neighbors out of a job.

Rhiannon: P-Pragmatist?

Hotelier: You know, pragmatism, it's all the rage with those big shots in London.

Though the hotelier himself doesn't fully understand the debates he's read about in the papers, the buzzword leaves Rhiannon downright stupefied.

???: Now now, what's all the fuss about?

Hotelier: Mrs. Owen, this young witch here's trying to check in without a shilling to her name!

Rhiannon: That's not. I wasn't trying to—!

The old woman raises a finger to her lips.

Mrs. Owen: Come now. We don't make scenes at the front desk. Think of the other guests.

Hotelier: This ...

Mrs. Owen waves her hand.

Mrs. Owen: Go help in the kitchen. I'll take care of this.

The hotelier gives a respectful nod and steps away from the counter. His deference speaks volumes about the woman.

Rhiannon: Ma'am, I'm so sorry. I didn't mean to cause any trouble. I just ...

Mrs. Owen: Thrown out by Dobharchú Tywyll, were you?

Rhiannon: What?

A bit of a mouthful for most, but to Rhiannon, that name carries a very different weight.

Rhiannon: You know—!

Mrs. Owen: That I do. Also had tea with Ivan, taught little Gwen her letters ... Why, I even went all the way to London to help Thomas get his hands on the latest bicycle.

Rhiannon's mother, father, cousin, and uncle. And that cerulean bicycle—she'd fallen off it once herself.

Her eyes are wide as saucers.

Mrs. Owen: And you, little Aderyn! Well, not so little now, I suppose. How have you been all these years? Old enough to travel on your own now, are you?

Rhiannon: I ... Mam and I have been secluded for so long, and yet you still know my name.

Rhiannon: I take it you're an old friend of the family?

The Adar Llwch Gwin dangling from her wand stares at Mrs. Owen as though trying to burn a hole right through her.

Rhiannon: Hey, quit your staring! It's terribly rude!

Mrs. Owen: It's quite alright, dear. I'm glad to see you and these little birds are getting along better now. Last time we met, you were little more than a babbling babe, and they were chasing you all over the place.

Mrs. Owen: Oh, how I miss those days, seeing the Tywyll children and their birds at the fair, laughter and chirps filling the streets.

Mrs. Owen: Your family was quite the prominent one back then. Had that big estate right outside of town. Not like now.

Rhiannon: ...

Mrs. Owen: Huh.

Mrs. Owen catches herself a moment too late.

Mrs. Owen: Forgive me, dear. You need a room for the night, don't you?

Rhiannon: Yes. Glyndŵr dropped me off. I have two, um, I guess you could call them friends. We agreed to meet here in town.

Mrs. Owen: Oh, that heartless Dobharchú, sending you off without so much as a shilling. I'd love to put you up for the night, but once word gets out ...

Rhiannon: Don't worry. I understand, Mrs. Owen.

Rhiannon picks up her bag and gives a small bow.

Mrs. Owen: Where are you off to, then?

Rhiannon: The ruins just outside town, ma'am. My friends and I would sometimes spend the night there when we were little.

Mrs. Owen: That won't do. That won't do at all!

Mrs. Owen takes her hands gently.

Mrs. Owen: Rest here a while. Have some tea and biscuits. And if you're tired, just let me know, and I'll show you to the break room.

Rhiannon: This ...

Rhiannon hesitates. Mrs. Owen's words carry a familiar warmth, yet they haven't seen each other in so long ...

So long, in fact, that Rhiannon can't find so much as a trace of her in her memory.

Mrs. Owen: I know, it's been so long I must seem like a right stranger to you. But we've got plenty of time to get reacquainted now, don't we?

Mrs. Owen: Come, have a seat. You can tell me about yourself, your remarkable little birds, or even your mean old witch of a mother, if you'd like.

Mrs. Owen: She's complained to me more times than I can count—said you never wanted to set out on your journey. And yet, here you are! So, where has our little Tywyll bird decided to fly off to?

Hearing the secret she'd only ever told her mother spoken back to her shatters what's left of her defenses.

Rhiannon: I can't believe she'd ... *sigh*

Rhiannon: Guess you might as well hear the whole thing, then. It all started that morning, the day before my birthday.

TO BE CONTINUED...

[English text unavailable]

COL-314602

Comes a Gentle Wind

Aderyn: Here I humbly stand at the cleft of the earth, beseeching Annwn's mercy.

Aderyn: I offer my flesh as pledge: grant me sight of this world and the worlds beyond!

Her eyes meet another's in the darkness, flashing with a golden hue.

Aderyn: Mhmm.

Nothing. Not so much as a breeze.

By the Mirror Lake

Light shimmers across the water. The giant bird's half-translucent tail feathers catch the color of it and quiver.

Glyndŵr: ...

Aderyn: Glyndŵr, did it work? Did the bond form?

The bird stares back at her without response.

Aderyn: Again? Hmm. Did I mess the incantation up somehow? Where'd I go wrong?

She draws a deep breath and points her wand at the lake.

Aderyn: Water ... Change the water.

The calm lake ripples as her incantation spreads across it. Then the water churns, and what rises from its surface is no longer mist.

Aderyn: ...

Colorful crystalline bubbles float upward, and the light they refract dances with the shadows on her face.

pop

The Adar Llwch Gwin tracks the rising bubbles with wide eyes. With but a flap of its wings, the bubbles burst one by one, falling back into the lake and taking the dreamy scene with them.

Adar Llwch Gwin Fledgling: Coo!

The little bird beats its wings to take off from the wand and settle atop Aderyn's head.

Aderyn: Stop it.

She lifts the fledgling from her hair and holds it close.

Aderyn: I still can't bond with Glyndŵr.

Aderyn: "A Tywyll of sixteen must journey far."

Aderyn: "With blessings and a dear companion's sight ..."

Aderyn: How am I to carry on the tradition if I can't so much as ...

With a sigh, she returns the little bird to her wand.

Then she turns to face the still-silent Glyndŵr.

Aderyn: You still won't accept me. Am I ... Am I still not worthy, Glyndŵr? Is that it?

Aderyn murmurs her worries as she strokes the Adar Llwch Gwin's smooth breast feathers.

Just as she's done after each of her many failed attempts before.

Glyndŵr: ...

Glyndŵr looks down at the dejected little witch and lets out a rumble unbefitting of a bird.

Aderyn: Nothing for it but to keep trying, I suppose.

But that inner door, as ever, stays shut.

Aderyn: Let's go home, Glyndŵr.

Glyndŵr: Coo.

Glyndŵr stoops obediently onto the ground, letting Aderyn climb onto his back.

Tylwyth Teg Berry Garden

bang

A sudden thudding against the wooden door startles the drowsy birds sheltering under the eaves of an otherwise quiet orchard.

The vine-choked latch rattles under the impact, no longer strong enough to contain the fearsome creature within—

Which promptly rolls its small and rotund form out.

???: Coo ...

Though freshly hatched, its feathered wings still wet and sticky, even, the hatchling waddles out for an adventure.

Adar Llwch Gwin Fledgling: Coo?

As if sensing trouble on the breeze, it rolls its round little body to one side, only to bump straight into the path of the very trouble it was avoiding.

Adar Llwch Gwin Fledgling: Coo!

The hatchling lets out a shrill chirp as the gust from Glyndŵr's wings sends it tumbling toward the well.

Before it can fall into the ice-cold water, though, a hand catches it.

Aderyn: You ...

She cups the tiny creature in her palms and looks it over, incredulous.

Unlike Glyndŵr's solid beak, this one is half-translucent, like a horse chestnut bud catching the early spring light—pale, curved, and new.

Aderyn: A newborn Adar Llwch Gwin?

Adar Llwch Gwin Fledgling: Gah!

Aderyn: But the nesting box's been empty for years. What winds brought you here, little lad?

It wriggles furiously, but there's no escaping the practiced bird trainer's hands.

Aderyn: Don't care for being called "little lad," do you?

Aderyn, unbothered by the sticky membrane coating the plump little bird, pinches both wings delicately and flips it over.

Aderyn: Oh. A girl! Do pardon me, miss.

Aderyn: Hmm. How about "Bechan"?

A hatchling this young has no understanding of her language. So, the gesture is just a silly trifle.

But the little creature struggles again, and tender as it looks, her beak is already sharp enough to draw faint lines across her palm.

Aderyn pulls her hand back. The hatchling seizes the moment and lifts her wings wide—

—only to crash helplessly to the ground.

Aderyn: Pfff.

Bechan rolls across the ground without any coordination, causing itself to pick up a solid coating of dust and debris.

Bechan: Coo ...

Aderyn scoops up the pitiful creature and brushes her off.

Aderyn: Not so fun being covered in dirt, is it?

She looks at Bechan with a bemused, almost maternal smile. The damp membrane and dust have mixed into clumps of mud caking her wings.

Aderyn: Don't you worry, little Bechan. I'll get you tidied right up.

She cleans the hatchling using some well water warmed with "Drako Drought," then dries her delicate down with "Flamo Flurry."

Three years without a hatchling to tend to, yet her hands still remember every step.

Bechan: Coo ...

The little bird sleepily sunbathing atop her wand is proof enough of that.

???: It's sunny in London, for a change.

Dobharchú: You should come to the witches' fair sometime, Aderyn. I'm certain you'd enjoy it.

A voice, attempting to speak with warmth yet unable to conceal the stiffness beneath, comes through the oil-and-grit-clouded water.

Dobharchú: Oh, this water is positively filthy. What have you been up to?

Aderyn: Mam.

Aderyn leans over the basin and stirs the water through which her mother is speaking, then carries the sleepy little Bechan over to it.

Aderyn: I, uh, I found her today, right outside the coop.

Dobharchú: Today? But whose could she be?

Dobharchú touches her chin as she looks past her daughter to the giant bird standing silent behind her.

Dobharchú: Glyndŵr?

Glyndŵr: ...

He replies with a huff.

Dobharchú: I'll get to the bottom of this. Remember to keep her warm.

Aderyn: Got it. So, uhm, when will you return?

The subject change is far from graceful, but when it comes to her mother, nothing ever is.

Dobharchú: Soon.

A shop bell chimes through the water. Dobharchú has stepped into a quiet store.

Dobharchú: I'm picking out some things for you to take on your journey. It's almost time, after all.

Aderyn: My journey ...

Dobharchú: A new wand, a tent enchanted with space-expansion, or you could pick your own. Whatever you'd like.

Aderyn: I ... I'd like ... No, I couldn't possibly ask for anything.

Aderyn: I don't deserve to go, Mam.

Aderyn: I failed. Again.

Dobharchú: ...

Aderyn's mouth opens and shuts as she struggles to find the words she wants to say.

Aderyn: Could you tell me ...

Aderyn: Was I too cowardly? You know that night? Is ... Is that why Glyndŵr still won't bond with me?

TO BE CONTINUED...

[English text unavailable]

COL-314603

The Growing Pain

Mrs. Owen: Poor thing.

Mrs. Owen dabs the corner of her eye with a handkerchief.

Mrs. Owen: I remember that night, the night the great Tywyll family scattered to the winds.

Like leaves fallen from an oak tree.

Mrs. Owen: I helped the surviving Tywylls move after the poachers had been driven off, you know.

Mrs. Owen: Some stayed in this very hotel until their new homes were built.

Rhiannon: Others traveled further. Cardiff, Dublin, London ... Some even crossed the pond.

Mrs. Owen: It was just Dobharchú that hid away with the birds, and you.

Mrs. Owen picks a bilberry from the fruit dish and holds it up to Bechan's beak.

Mrs. Owen: I know just how hard it is for a teenager to live the same day over and over. My own daughter could hardly stay put for two days without getting restless.

Mrs. Owen: Your mother said you were only a child then, and you did everything you could.

Mrs. Owen: Why would you think that you weren't brave enough?

Dobharchú: Why would you think that you weren't brave enough?

Aderyn: If only I'd been braver, if I hadn't frozen, if I hadn't been thrown from the fight ...

Aderyn: Could I have saved them? Would Tad still be ...

Dobharchú: Aderyn!

Dobharchú's smile fades, and she says her name with an almost scolding tone.

Dobharchú: You were twelve years old.

Dobharchú: This should never have been your burden to bear.

Aderyn: ...

Aderyn: You always shut me out like this, like I wasn't even part of it!

Aderyn: What if—even if there's only one chance in a thousand, even ten thousand—

Aderyn: What if I could've defeated those poachers?!

Dobharchú: Aderyn ...

The water sloshes out of the basin, and her words dissolve into the spillage.

Aderyn: ...

Aderyn purses her lips and steps back, pulling her feet away from the dirty water creeping toward her.

Aderyn: I ...

In the end, nothing comes out.

After a moment, she turns toward the fading sunlight, pushes open the orchard gate, and walks into the woods without looking back.

Deep in the Forest

Years of neglect have seen nature reclaim the path to the place she once called home.

Now she struggles through the waist-high grass, guided only by moonlight.

Aderyn: ...

She pushes away the wild overgrowth. The rustling sound rolls outward in waves all the way to the forest's edge.

Aderyn: Glyndŵr? Are you there?

A cold gleam of moonlight sweeps across the empty corner behind her and disappears.

Aderyn: Just like back then ...

Aderyn: A moonless night with a chilly breeze.

Aderyn: I would've been bumbling around in the dark if it weren't for my arcane skill's glow.

Aderyn: I offer my flesh ... as pledge: grant me sight ... of ...

Aderyn: ... this world and ... the worlds beyond?

Aderyn stumbles through the incantation, and energy pours out from the tip of the birch branch she's holding.

The arcane skill forms a string of incomprehensible symbols, then sinks into Glyndŵr's feathers.

Aderyn: Well? Did it work, Glyndŵr?!

For a moment, her eager face is illuminated not by moonlight, but by an arcane glow.

Aderyn: The bonding—it worked, right? Please tell me it worked!

Glyndŵr: Coo.

He raises his wings and preens his feathers ruffled by arcane energy.

Aderyn: Mhmm.

Aderyn closes her eyes. She tries to shut out the world, tries to perceive with her heart, and yet ...

There's nothing to perceive.

Her elders had always said the incantation flows between witches and their bonded Adar Llwch Gwin. But where there should be a stream, she can feel only the void of space between them.

Aderyn: I ... I see.

Glyndŵr's silence drives her mad. Her cheeks puff, and her arms fling outward—an attempt at some kind of bird body language.

Aderyn: You're real stingy, you know that?

Aderyn: I thought we were friends! But you—you won't even let me borrow your sight! Is a bird's-eye view too much to ask for?!

Glyndŵr: Coo?

Aderyn: Don't you "coo" me! I'm not forgiving you, you-you big birdbrain!

She slumps to the ground with a huff. Glyndŵr looks down at her, then settles to give her a soft wall of feathers to rest against.

And just like that, all is forgiven.

Aderyn: Is it because you think I'm not strong enough? But I've already mastered 32 arcane skills! That's got to count for something!

Glyndŵr huffs out a warm breath. Aderyn can read the incredulous "really?" written on his face.

He had, after all, been there the day she burned off her father's eyebrows with "Drako Drought."

Aderyn: Alright, "mastered" might be a stretch.

Aderyn: But I ... I'm still really strong, aren't I? Why, one day, I'll be as strong as the goddess Rhiannon herself!

Aderyn makes a fist and swings it through the air.

bang

Aderyn: Huh?!

Aderyn: ...!

A fiery glow rises from the horizon beyond the surrounding trees.

Another explosion. Red and orange bloom across the sky.

For a moment, her mind goes blank, then adrenaline yanks her back.

Aderyn: That's ... No!

Aderyn: Glyndŵr! Quick, fly back! Go without me!

Without a moment's hesitation, he spreads his wings and vanishes into the night.

Aderyn's little legs fight the knee-high grass as she sprints toward the blazing sky.

She still clings to a shred of hope.

But the fire swallowing her home threatens to burn that shred of hope away.

Aderyn: Fire ...

Aderyn: Tad! Mam! Gwen!

The sight of strangers stops her from calling out any more loved ones' names.

Outsider: A straggler, is it? Don't let her get away!

She tightens her grip on her birch branch.

TO BE CONTINUED...

[English text unavailable]

COL-314604

The Darkest Hour

Tywyll Estate

Her father used to say with a smile that fire was the greediest child of all.

Aderyn never agreed, for she had the biggest appetite, the most strength, and the sturdiest body. How could a few little flames rival the greatest Tywyll of them all?

Aderyn: Tad ... Mam! Where are you?!

The doorframe etched with the heights of generations of Tywyll children, the birdhouse built to mark their first Adar Llwch Gwin's hatch day, the oak tree her mother had brought all the way from her hometown when it was just a sapling ...

The heat and smoke force tears from her eyes.

Aderyn: You were right, Tad. It really is the greediest.

She staggers toward the blaze. The arcane barrier she conjures barely reaches her skin before it's seared away.

Aderyn: Ow!

The flames devouring the manor taunt her with the crackling and groans of long-dried wood.

Aderyn: Where is everyone?

Aderyn: Glyndŵr!

The bird's cry cuts through the heavy smoke, letting a sliver of pale moonlight fall on the center of the fire.

Aderyn: ...!

Aderyn: Tad ... Tad!

She tears away from her original path and veers toward the heart of the flames.

Aderyn's Father: Stay back!

She halts. There's something in his shout, something ragged and broken that she's never heard from him before.

Aderyn: ...

His contorted face is covered in sweat and blackened by smoke.

She can't help but take two steps forward. Her eyes strain to see past the flames.

Aderyn: Hmm?

Her foot catches something soft.

Aderyn: Gwen?

Her cousin lies still on the scorched earth. Her lovely red locks are now charred and brittle.

She's curled up as if slumbering. No, she's clutching something, something small and gray.

Its young feathers—feathers that once cut through wind and caught the light—are now limp and dull.

Aderyn: Gwen? Gwen? Get up. You have to run!

Aderyn's voice scrapes against her throat like a rusted blade.

She rubs her eyes with shaky hands, trying to see through the wall of fire.

Aderyn's Father: Aderyn, run!

But she pushes through the flames and sees everything.

Every shred of hope turns to ash and blows away on the wind.

She can make out the dark silhouettes of some other Tywylls amid the flames. Some are standing, while others, like Gwen, have fallen.

Aderyn: ...

Aderyn: Ah!

Her mouth gapes as if to scream, but nothing comes out.

Outsider: Grab her! She's an arcanist!

Aderyn spins around. The slumber incantation she casts is clumsy and unpracticed; they slump to the ground, but their eyes close for only a moment.

They stagger back up and raise their axes toward her. Their smoke-reddened eyes blaze out of their ash-covered faces like something from a nightmare.

Poacher: Are you gonna let a little brat get the best of you?!

The outsiders burst into laughter, as if her burning home was nothing more than a bonfire to them.

Aderyn's Father: Don't touch her!

Her father struggles against his restraints, but the enchanted rope holds him fast.

Aderyn raises her wand breathless, only to find that sparks have already reduced her birch branch to charcoal.

Aderyn: T-Tad ...

Poacher: How touching. We could let her go, of course.

A sinister grin spreads across his face.

Poacher: You call yourselves protectors. But just how far do those ideals extend, I wonder.

Poacher: Quite the flock you've got here. Invisibility, speed, loyalty—ancient arcanum's gift to the modern world. Worth a whole air fleet, the lot of 'em are.

Poacher: We'll let one of you survive for each one of the birds you give up.

Aderyn's Father: ...

Aderyn: The-The birds?

Her gaze shifts toward Glyndŵr.

The strongest adult Adar Llwch Gwin of the Tywyll family.

Her father's friend and partner. Her guardian and playmate.

Aderyn's Father: Aderyn ...

His voice is helpless, resigned.

It's the same sort of half-scolding, half-indulgent sigh she'd hear whenever she misbehaved.

Aderyn's Father: Glyndŵr! Get her out of here!

The giant bird surges upward in one sweep of his wings. Before Aderyn can even react, her collar is yanked tight from behind, and her feet leave the ground.

Aderyn: No, don't! Stop it!

Glyndŵr: Coo ...

Her struggling only makes the bird beat his wings harder.

Aderyn: Glyndŵr! Put me down! I'm not leaving!

She knows it's no use. A full-grown Adar Llwch Gwin can fly faster than even the strongest of gales. Through teary eyes, Aderyn watches her home, once lush green turned burning red, disappear from view.

Aderyn: *whimper*

Aderyn: I offer my flesh as pledge: grant me sight of this world and the worlds beyond!

Glyndŵr: ...?!

Glyndŵr opens his talons as he comes down for a landing, letting Aderyn tumble into the soft grass.

He folds his wings and stands over her like a proud gray oak. His golden eyes are looking down on the weeping girl.

Aderyn: Go. Just-Just go!

She pushes herself up from the grass and shoves at the giant bird with all her strength, but Aderyn can't move him an inch.

Aderyn: I'm fine; save THEM! Please! Go!

Her broken cries scatter in the wind. Glyndŵr's golden pupils narrow into pinpoints.

He opens his wings just a little and moves instinctively toward the trembling girl.

Aderyn: Please ...

Aderyn reaches her tear-streaked hands up to lay them against his beak.

Glyndŵr: Coo.

He gives Aderyn a long, sympathetic look.

Then he spreads his wings wide. The resulting gust rolls across the sea of grass like a tide as he takes to the now moonlit sky and flies back toward the rising smoke and orange-glowing flames.

Aderyn crumples onto the ground. She's left with only the crisp midnight wind to comfort her; it tears her heart open, and through it, they wail together.

TO BE CONTINUED...

[English text unavailable]

COL-314605

A Willing Exile

As this chapter of her tale comes to an end, the room falls into a stunned silence.

Mrs. Owen: Oh ... I'm so sorry, my dear. It must have been terribly painful to remember that night.

For once, Mrs. Owen's composure fails her. She fumbles between reaching for either her handkerchief or Rhiannon's hand, yet she manages neither.

Mrs. Owen: You've done nothing wrong, child.

Mrs. Owen: Running into the fire—trying to find your family—was not a mistake. Neither was surviving it.

Rhiannon goes still.

Rhiannon: That's ... That's what Mam told me.

Aderyn's ears flush as she thinks of how stubborn she'd been, wondering at how long she had misunderstood those words.

She reaches for her tea, only to find the cup empty.

Hotelier: What happened next?

The hotelier, teapot in hand yet engrossed in the story, moves reflexively to refill her cup.

Hotelier: Ah, right, sugar?

Rhiannon: Um, no, thank you.

Rhiannon: As for what happened next ...

Rhiannon: All the smoke I'd breathed in left me quite ill, so the days that followed were mostly spent in bed.

Rhiannon: By the time I'd recovered, Mam had already taken care of everything.

Aderyn: ...

You wouldn't have even known there was a fire, from the look of it.

Even that acrid, smoky stench had disappeared, replaced by something so sterile it felt unnatural.

Aderyn: Where am I?

Aderyn pulls herself out of bed—a makeshift thing of wood planks and a pile of furs so thick one might mistake her for the selfsame protagonist of *The Princess and the Pea*.

Aderyn: Mam!

Tywyll Estate Ruins

The first thing she sees when she steps outside is her mother, back turned to her, drawing shapes in the air with her wand.

She stands at the center of blackened earth ravaged by fire and grief. A faint arcane glow envelops her fingertips and ripples out.

Then a soft drizzle falls from the blue sky, erasing stains and soothing the wounds of the earth.

Aderyn: Mam. Mam.

Only then does Aderyn notice just how scratchy and raw she sounds.

The witch pauses. The light at her fingers is fading as she turns.

Dobharchú's eyes are dry, her face home to a tranquility that looks forced and exhausting to uphold. It frightens Aderyn more than any tear-stained sorrow could.

Aderyn: What about the others? What about Glyndŵr? A-And Tad?

Dobharchú crouches down to meet her daughter's wide, worried eyes.

Dobharchú: By the time I got back, it was too late.

Aderyn: But you're ... you're restoring the defensive array?

Dobharchú: Your father activated it in the end. We've been exposed, but anyone who comes sniffing around after deserves what they'll find.

Her tone matches her face, serene, daring, and unbothered.

And yet the words fall on Aderyn's heart like cold raindrops from an approaching storm.

Despite being a witch of water, this is one raincloud she's powerless to cast away.

Aderyn: I ...

Aderyn's world goes silent. Her mouth moves; no sound follows, but salty, warm tears find their way inside.

Aderyn: Boohoo. Booaaah ...

Sobs rack her body as she curls into herself.

Dobharchú doesn't stop her, nor does she offer any comfort. She simply sits beside her, keeping her daughter at arm's length like a distant, silent dam, bearing the weight of her tears.

Her hands rest on her knees, knuckles white. She waits for the flood to stop surging.

Time crawls on. Once the sobs finally give way to choked, ragged breaths, Dobharchú stands.

Dobharchú: Have you cried it all out?

Her stark composure leaves Aderyn without a refuge.

Aderyn: M-Mam, you ...

Dobharchú reaches out, not to wipe away her daughter's tears, but to brush the last specks of ash from the ends of her hair.

Dobharchú: Here ...

Dobharchú: This place has nothing left for us. Leave your tears here as well, Aderyn.

Aderyn: But, but this is our ...

The word "home" is still lingering heavy on her tongue when Dobharchú offers her hand.

The morning light falling on her face highlights a steely calm behind all the fatigue.

Dobharchú: Come, Aderyn. It's time to leave.

She looks around at the charred ruin—a home no longer.

Aderyn: Leave? Where to?

Dobharchú: Somewhere you can learn to breathe again.

They pass through valleys filled with ancient forests painted in sun-dappled shadows, flying fast and far in an attempt to outrun the heartache.

At last, they arrive ...

Rhiannon: Sorry, I can't tell you exactly where.

Rhiannon: That road was really long, so long I thought it'd never end.

Rhiannon: It did, eventually. I remember Mam parting a curtain of vines dotted with small white flowers.

The first thing to hit Aderyn is the scent of sweet fruit and damp earth, and then the sight of sunlight filtering down through the canopy, warm and honey-gold.

Aderyn: ...!

At the heart of the orchard, beneath the most gnarled of the fruit trees, nests a large feathered form.

The bird's wings are folded over his puffed-up body, sheltering a clutch of gray-speckled eggs.

He rests his head against one of them, listening for the faint rhythm of life within.

Aderyn: Glyndŵr!

The giant bird turns his head, his eyes no longer blazing gold but instead a calm amber.

He meets Aderyn's gaze. She sees neither reproach nor grief in his eyes, only an understanding serenity.

Aderyn: Mam! Glyndŵr's here. Does that mean the others ...

The reply comes like a calm breeze, unbothered as it snuffs out the last sparks of her hopes.

Dobharchú: We're all that's left, Aderyn.

Aderyn: I ... I don't understand.

Dobharchú: When dawn came, we made a decision: the surviving Tywylls would scatter—the others are bound for Cardiff, Dublin, London, even Paris ...

Aderyn: I thought you said we're the only ones left.

Dobharchú: And we are. Conflict is sweeping the world. Those greedy, fanatical eyes, the same ones you saw that night, will stop at nothing to take all that they can exploit.

Dobharchú: We will not let our dearest companions be made into weapons of war.

Dobharchú: That's why we must let the Adar Llwch Gwin fade into legend—into a myth whose very existence people will come to doubt.

Aderyn: It's the only way to protect them, and the safest. I know that.

Dobharchú: I believe so.

She looks over to her young daughter and speaks again.

Dobharchú: The other survivors will move elsewhere with only their necessary memories and a carefully constructed story.

Dobharchú: There, they'll live "ordinary" lives, guarding the "legend" of the Adar Llwch Gwin.

Dobharchú: As for Glyndŵr and I ... We will stay here, sheltered by layers of incantations and hidden from the world.

Aderyn: For how long?

Dobharchú: Until time brings us a better answer. Or until one is not needed.

Dobharchú: This is the promise I made to your father, the unfinished work I will carry on in his stead.

Her voice grows both softer and more certain.

Dobharchú: It need not be your path, Aderyn. You can write a story that has nothing to do with legends or history—a story that's wholly yours.

She pauses and then breaks the cold barrier between them to rest her hands on her daughter's shoulders.

Dobharchú: I can't make this choice for you. I know that staying here means ...

Aderyn: No more playing in the woods. And—and no more school, either. I'd have to say goodbye to my friends, my teachers ...

Dobharchú watches tears well in the corners of her daughter's reddening eyes and draws a deep breath.

Dobharchú: I could send you to your aunt's in Perthshire, far enough, and safe. Or I can enroll you at a secluded school where the teachers will look after you.

Aderyn: Mam ...

Aderyn: H-How can you be so calm? Tad's gone. Everyone else has left, and-and now you want to send me away, too.

Aderyn: You ... Aren't you sad? Why won't you cry?

Dobharchú: There's no room for tears. Not for me, and not for you.

She rises to her feet and approaches Glyndŵr, still nesting beneath the gnarled old tree.

Dobharchú: This isn't your burden to bear, Aderyn.

Aderyn: I ...

Dobharchú waits as her daughter sobs. Even the wind seems to still in patient anticipation.

TO BE CONTINUED...

[English text unavailable]

COL-314606

Honeyed Words

Mrs. Owen: Ah, yes, that's the Dobharchú I know.

Mrs. Owen: Tender yet heartless. A witch among witches. The most mysterious of all arcanists.

Rhiannon scratches her cheek, at a loss.

As a daughter, she ought to defend her mother. But she knows Mrs. Owen is right.

Mrs. Owen: And then? I heard you fought with Dobharchú the eve of your sixteenth birthday and stormed off.

Rhiannon: No. I mean, I wouldn't call that a fight, exactly.

Rhiannon: Mam was only trying to comfort me. I just didn't want to listen, so I left.

Hotelier: Oh! Ran away from home, did you?

Rhiannon: N-No, nothing like that!

Rhiannon: I wanted to see home again. Our old home. Just for a visit to pay my respects to Tad and the others.

Trouble always comes without warning.

Aderyn: Ŝvebi Stay!

The leaf-covered ground gives way, sending her plummeting into a pit. Only a quick burst of arcane energy keeps her from hitting the bottom.

Glyndŵr: Coo?

The Adar Llwch Gwin, far too large to fall in, crouches at the edge. He peers down and calls out, worried.

Aderyn: I'm fine.

The pit reeks of rot and metal. The sight of a rope net rigged at the bottom sends a bead of cold dripping down her back.

Aderyn: What is that?

???: Think we got something! Go on, check if it's a big one!

Before she can process what's happening, the sound of footsteps and clanging metal closes in from outside the trees.

Aderyn: Glyndŵr! Take them away!

She grabs a fledgling from her shoulder and holds it up, trying to get it to fly, but the malicious voices boom too close for escape.

Aderyn: Quick! Turn invisible!

Glyndŵr has already concealed himself within the light, but the two fledglings clinging to Aderyn have yet to master that trick.

Several rough, avaricious faces crowd around the pit's edge.

Poacher I: Oi! It's a girl, and she's got some chicks!

Poacher II: That tip-off was money well-spent, it was. Young Adar Llwch Gwins ...

Poacher II: Just imagine the Sharpodonties we can get for those on the black market!

A hand snatches at her shoulder. The frightened fledglings crouch and puff their feathers.

Aderyn's body reacts before her mind can.

She throws herself to the far side of the pit, but she's not fast enough to escape the greedy, calloused fingertips that graze her collar.

Poacher I: Tsk!

As she sees the glint of drawn weapons above her, a bold idea takes shape.

Aderyn: W-Wait! Don't ... Don't hurt them or me.

She tilts her head back. Moonlight filters through the canopy above to highlight her mud-smeared face and the helpless, panicked expression she puts on display.

Aderyn tightens her hold on the fledglings. Perhaps it's her imagination, but the little birds seem to understand.

Aderyn: The ... The bigger ones sell for more, right? That's what you're after—full-grown birds?

She gulps to sell the idea that she's steeling herself to divulge a secret.

Aderyn: I know a place. There's a nest, more than one bird. If you let me and the fledglings go ...

The poachers look at each other with narrowed eyes, weighing her words.

Poacher I: Lying to us won't end well for you.

Aderyn: Of course! I'm a hunter, so I know these woods. I came across the nest by accident. It's well hidden. In ... In a ruin, to the east.

Aderyn: I-It's where I found these ones! Look!

Convinced by the fledglings in her arms, they drop a rope into the pit.

Poacher II: Climb up.

Aderyn settles the fledglings back onto her wand, grabs the rope, and pulls herself out.

She may have made it out of the trap and back into the moonlight, but she can't help feeling as though she's stepped into a far more dangerous cage.

Aderyn: Th-This way. Let's go.

She points to what she remembers to be east, keeping just the right amount of fear in her voice.

Aderyn: It's a bit of a walk.

Poacher I: Don't try nothing.

The lead poacher pats his holstered weapon, letting its presence finish the threat.

Aderyn: Of course, as long as you're willing to spare me and my birds.

Aderyn: A-And if you could deal with the large one at the nest, I'd be even more grateful.

Poacher II: Got in over your head with the big one, did you?

Aderyn: Yes. I mean, I stole these two from the nest, so ...

Poacher I: Oh? They say Adar Llwch Gwins are known to hold grudges.

Aderyn: Yes, exactly. That's why the big one won't leave me alone.

Aderyn: But after hatching them, caring for them, I can't bring myself to give them back.

Poacher II: Ha! You've got nerve, I'll give you that.

The poachers shove her forward, and they set off.

Aderyn leads them with a limp and a nervous smile on her face. Every step she takes weaves another thread into a dangerous lie.

Her palms are clammy, but the chilly wind dries them somewhat. She wants to believe it's Glyndŵr, silently watching from above.

Aderyn: I have to do this.

She has to keep up the act, either until an opportunity presents itself or she's backed into a corner.

TO BE CONTINUED...

[English text unavailable]

COL-314607

Scorching Wrath

Darkness gives way to dawn.

The still-sleepy sunrise bathes everything in a pale glow.

And as they reach the path's end, in that radiance capable of bringing every secret to light, a scorched ruin looms ahead.

Aderyn: Here, here it is.

The breeze carries a familiar scent.

No longer the sweetness of the orchard, it's all ash and grief, soaked so deep into the soil and rubble that no amount of rain could hope to wash it away.

A few burned and broken walls—skeletal remains poking out from a grave—are all that remain of her home.

Aderyn: ...

Sounds she had hoped to forget come back to her: the crackling of burning wood, her own panicked cries, and the Adar Llwch Gwins' mournful calls.

Whatever joy her sixteenth birthday should have brought is replaced by something else—a marrow-deep guilt she'd never been able to shake.

Now, in this charred, dead ruin, it wakes again, far more terrible than before.

Aderyn: If only I'd been braver, if I hadn't frozen ...

Aderyn: If Glyndŵr hadn't needed to rescue me, if he'd just stayed with Tad, he might've ... might've ...

Again and again, she's punished herself for this sin for not being "enough."

???: Leave, Aderyn.

A childlike voice in the back of her mind, caught between calm and crying, commands her.

???: Turn invisible. Turn back.

???: Go back to the orchard. Reinforce the rituals. You can't afford another mistake, so leave it to someone who won't make one. Wait for Mam. She'll handle it.

There's the voice again, timid yet tempting. She can't deny that its logic is sound.

Aderyn: Invisibility ...

She finds safety in the idea; like a siren call, it feels dark and yet almost irresistible.

She can feel the arcane energy she inherited from her mother stirring. It's desperate to conceal her, desperate to wipe away every trace of her presence.

One incantation—one of the few she knows by heart—and she would vanish. She could leave these poachers to a stronger, more reliable witch.

Aderyn: I ...

???: Now, Aderyn, go.

Her steps slow, coming just shy of a complete stop.

Her grip on her wand tightens, and a faint glow manifests around her trembling hand. Just as she's about to release the arcane energy, though, she catches the glint of her little companion's eyes.

Bechan: Coo!

Bechan's wide, bright eyes reflect her own hesitant face. Layered on top of it is another pair of eyes, looking right back at her.

They're the same eyes that watched her from the scorched ground, right until the bitter end. They're eyes filled with both despair and resolve—eyes that, despite it all, never backed down.

???: Leave. You have to leave before it's too late.

Aderyn: No.

She grips her wand. The arcane glow has expanded to engulf her white knuckles.

Aderyn: I could make a mess of everything again.

Aderyn: And maybe I'm not really sure what I ought to do, but ...

Aderyn: I won't just lead the danger elsewhere and push my responsibility onto someone else.

???: ...

???: I'm proud of you, Aderyn.

The voice fades.

Poacher II: What're you dragging your feet for? Come on, get moving!

She draws a deep breath. The cool air, thick with ash and memories, fills her lungs and sweeps all thoughts of retreat from her mind.

Aderyn: This is it, gentlemen.

Poacher I: Here?

The poachers whoop in triumph and begin searching the charred ruin for their quarry.

Now.

Crimson flames shoot from her wand, ensnaring the wrist of the bow-wielding poacher.

Poacher II: Aaaaghhhhh!!

The bow falls to the ground as he clutches his arm and begins rolling in the dirt.

Aderyn doesn't hesitate. A second Drako Drought is already charging in her wand.

Poacher I: Damn it. I knew you were up to something.

The poacher's hand flies to the weapon at his hip.

Aderyn: Drako Drought!

bang

Her flames shatter the projectile just as it leaves the barrel. She'd never encountered a firearm before, never really understood how it worked. The shower of hot sparks and metal slag catches her off-guard.

Aderyn: Urgh!

The surprise sends her stumbling back.

Poacher I: Some guide you turned out to be.

Poacher I: Those two chicks of yours will more than make up for the trouble, though, wouldn't you say?

Just as the leering poacher raises his weapon again, the winds shift without warning.

Aderyn: Glyndŵr!

The gray silhouette plunges in a headlong dive.

Poacher I: The net!

A large net with an eerie shimmer drops right into Glyndŵr's path.

buzzzzz

The sound it emits makes Aderyn's skin crawl, but it is the cry of pain and fury that Glyndŵr lets out that truly breaks her heart.

Glyndŵr: *shriek*

No longer able to sustain his harmonization of light and shadow, the illusion blurring him falls, leaving Glyndŵr fully exposed.

Poacher II: It worked! It really worked! A full-grown Adar Llwch Gwin—a live one, at that!

Poacher I: So that bloody brat didn't … No, no, she tricked us, but it don't matter one bit! We've nabbed ourselves a big one!

The poachers celebrate their catch, but Aderyn doesn't move just yet.

Aderyn: Phew.

She bends down.

Her fingers sink deep into the blackened earth in search of a pulse—of the last sign of life in her long-dead home.

Aderyn: Our defensive ritual …

The arcane energy thins to the faintest threads, weaving through the scarred dirt and remnant ash to find a way up.

Aderyn: Water, return to this earth its stolen peace.

A low rumble rises from below.

Poacher I: What's that?

He grips his gun and raises it toward Aderyn, but he's too late.

One by one, azure incantations blaze across the dead earth, and an underground river breaks through, soft yet unyielding.

Poacher II: Wh-What! *gasp*

Poacher I: N-No! *gurgle*

The water coils around their heads like a python, seizing their air with brutal tenderness.

As the poachers go down, Aderyn sprints toward her ensnared companion.

Aderyn: Glyndŵr!

She throws herself over the fallen bird and cuts the sinister net away with precise arcane skill, taking care not to injure Glyndŵr.

Once freed, Glyndŵr bows his head to nudge Aderyn's forehead with his large beak.

???: Glyndŵr? Aderyn?!

TO BE CONTINUED...

[English text unavailable]

COL-314608

Goes a Gentle Wind

A travel-worn Dobharchú stands at the edge of the scorched ground, silky hair loose and tangled over her shoulders.

Her eyes are wide with shock and a worry that hasn't quite settled.

Aderyn: Mam!

She scrambles to her feet.

Aderyn: Why are you ... N-No. How did you know I was here?

Dobharchú: The ritual was triggered. And, well, call it a mother's intuition.

She hurries to her daughter's side, eyes darting over every nick and scratch.

Dobharchú: What happened? You're hurt.

Satisfied that her daughter is otherwise safe, Dobharchú turns her piercing gaze on the poachers.

Aderyn pulls her shoulders back, and though her voice is still somewhat shaky, she recounts what happened with more than a little pride.

Aderyn: Poachers, just like that time. They wanted Adar Llwch Gwins! But I—I mean, me and Glyndŵr, we beat them!

She points eagerly at the Aqua Gaol ritual's aftermath.

Aderyn: Glyndŵr protected me, and I activated your ritual, and I protected him!

Aderyn: I protected the flock! I didn't run. I faced them. I ...

She draws a breath and meets her mother's eyes.

Aderyn: I proved I could do it! I ... I'm brave enough now, aren't I?

But her mother doesn't allow for any celebration just yet.

She looks over those extraordinarily bright eyes, that still-childlike face, at the bloodied scrapes and bruises that cover her from head to toe.

Dobharchú: Aderyn!

Her voice is sharp and stern.

Dobharchú: Why did you ever think you needed to prove it to me?

Aderyn is stunned.

All those words of bravery and victory lodge in her throat, choking her. She blinks, as if she hasn't quite understood the question.

Aderyn: I ... B-Because ...

Dobharchú: You kept the nest secret. You protected Glyndŵr and the fledglings. You even activated my ritual. You know, at your age, I struggled to even light a fire.

She speaks with careful, weighted words.

Dobharchú: All of that is remarkable, far beyond anything I expect of you. But, Aderyn ...

She pauses, looking into her daughter's bewildered eyes, reaching for that knot of doubt within that never came loose.

Dobharchú: Why would you think you have to prove your bravery to me?

Aderyn: I couldn't protect Tad. I failed so, so many times to bond with Glyndŵr. And yet you never blamed me for any of it, never asked anything of me.

Aderyn: I thought I'd let you down ... That you'd given up ...

Dobharchú: No, Aderyn, I'd only thought that I should bear the Tywyll family's burdens alone—bear its grudges and all that comes with them on my own.

Dobharchú: Your father, your cousin, all the others who fell ... They were robbed of their chance to move forward. But I thought, if I could shoulder it all, then perhaps at least you could fly free.

Dobharchú: I never would have imagined you felt that way.

Her voice carries no blame, only deep confusion and a love tinged with the remnants of grief.

Dobharchú: From the moment you ran back into the fire for our family, from the moment you chose to stay, quietly caring for the fledglings, enduring the loneliness without ever complaining ...

Dobharchú: No, from the very day you were born ...

Dobharchú: You've always been the bravest girl I could ask for and one I couldn't be more proud of. That courage has always been inside you.

Dobharchú: You could never let me down.

Aderyn: I ... but I ...

Glyndŵr coos as if to echo Dobharchú's words.

He shakes out the feathers the net had flattened and rises unsteadily to his feet, wings stirring up a gust of wind in the process.

Aderyn: Glyndŵr! You're hurt; you shouldn't—

"Aderyn."

Aderyn: *yelp*

Aderyn: You—you can talk?

All at once, the world and its sounds fade. The breeze sweeping through her home's remains, her mother's breathing, the soft rustle of the valley trees ... All are miles away.

She looks into the Adar Llwch Gwin's great golden eyes and sees herself staring back.

A startled face, eyes holding back tears—crystal clear yet so unfamiliar.

Then there's a voice, heard not through her ears, but somewhere in the depths of her heart.

Aderyn: "You seek answers in books, in the arcane skills they teach you, yet never have you ever listened to your own heartbeat ..."

Her breath catches in her chest.

Aderyn: "Dobharchú and I are waiting ... till the day ... you see yourself ..."

The voice speaks with relief; this has been a long time coming.

The chains that bound her innermost self snap, and the shell that shielded her heart cracks open from within, broken by a light that has always been there—a light finally given the chance to shine.

The bond.

The bond from that night—the one sealed by the order to leave her behind.

Aderyn: *whimper*

Aderyn: *crying*

Tears cascade down her cheeks.

Tears only for herself.

For the girl who ran into the blaze only to find herself helpless within them. For the girl who practiced her arcane skills alone by the water. For the girl who stumbled her way to the present, weighed down by her own perceived shortcomings.

Aderyn: M-Mam ... *whimper*

Aderyn: Ooh! I'm sorry. O-Oh, no.

Dobharchú: There's nothing to be sorry for, my "Rhiannon."

Dobharchú: It looks like you've acknowledged your bond with Glyndŵr. You can finally set out now. Come now, don't cry. It means you've grown up.

Aderyn: B-But I don't ... *sob* I'm not g-going anywhere.

Mrs. Owen: On your twelfth birthday, your answer was to stay.

Mrs. Owen: You gave up the open sky and rooted yourself to the earth instead. You made a choice few could.

Mrs. Owen: Now you're a young woman, already sixteen. Are you not curious what the world has to offer?

Rhiannon: It's ... It's so hard to choose. Back home, there's a familiarity; I know what it is to be happy there. But outside, I can't say what's waiting for me.

Rhiannon: Before, I didn't know whether I'd go, or how far, or for how long, and to tell you the truth, I still don't.

She looks up, her eyes shining bright.

Rhiannon: But here I am, outside, in the great unknown.

Rhiannon: And now, I want to see all those places from Mam and Tad's bedtime stories.

Her tone is confident, free, and certain, as though she's at last confirming a long-held truth.

Mrs. Owen: I see ...

Mrs. Owen: Well, would you look at the time? Morning already.

Mrs. Owen: I won't keep you any longer, Rhiannon. Go. Go and see all there is to see.

Mrs. Owen, now satisfied, escorts her guest out with the same resolve she'd shown when she insisted Rhiannon stay the night.

Rhiannon leaves the inn, then turns and waves to "Mrs. Owen."

Rhiannon: Goodbye, Mam! We'll write to you as often as we can!

"Mrs. Owen" pauses. Then, her lips curl into a smile.

"Mrs. Owen": That's my girl.

"Mrs. Owen's" face begins to shift and distort, her bones and cartilage rearranging themselves beneath the skin.

Though somewhat obscured by the black veil, the sharp, elegant features that emerge can belong to only one woman.

Dobharchú: I told myself if you carelessly told a stranger all our family business, I'd have had no choice but to take you home.

Dobharchú: When did you figure it out?

Rhiannon gives a proud little flourish with her wand, and the perched Adar Llwch Gwin fledglings chirp in celebration.

Rhiannon: I knew it all along, Mam.